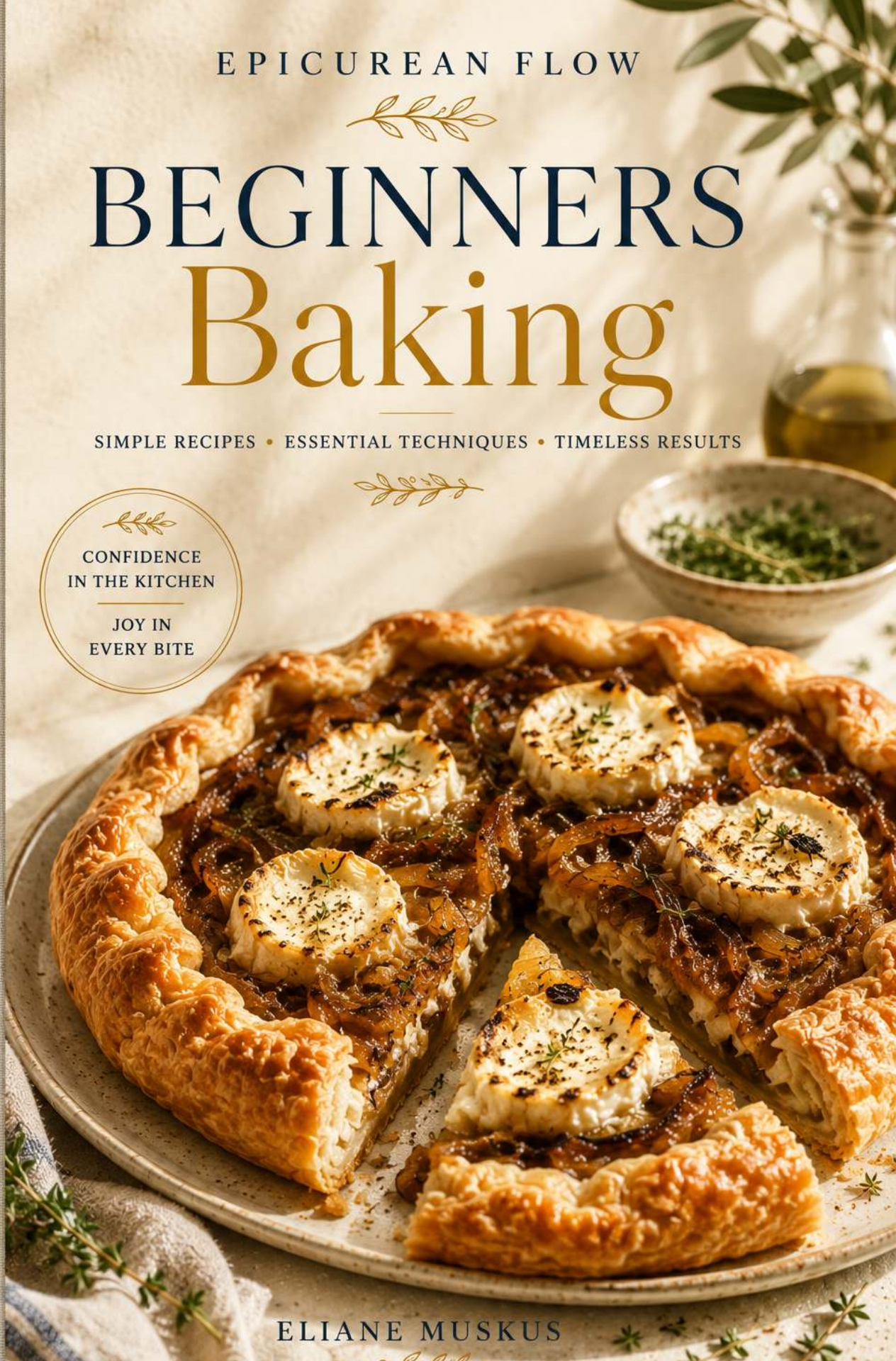
EPICUREAN FLOW

BEGINNERS Baking

SIMPLE RECIPES • ESSENTIAL TECHNIQUES • TIMELESS RESULTS

CONFIDENCE IN THE KITCHEN

JOY IN EVERY BITE



ELIANE MUSKUS

EPICUREAN FLOW

Baking for Beginners

Bake with Confidence from Day One

SIMPLE RECIPES | ESSENTIAL TECHNIQUES | TIMELESS RESULTS

CHEF ELIANE MUSKUS

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This course is intended for educational purposes. Baking results may vary depending on ingredients, equipment and individual experience.

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WELCOME

Welcome to Your Baking Journey

Confidence begins with a few reliable tools, a handful of ingredients and the willingness to learn.

When people discover that I'm a chef, one of the first things they tell me is:

"I'd love to bake, but I'm afraid I'll get it wrong."

If that sounds familiar, you're in exactly the right place.

The wonderful thing about baking is that nobody is born knowing how to make the perfect loaf of bread or a beautifully risen cake.

Every experienced baker started exactly where you are today, with curiosity, a few simple ingredients and the willingness to learn.

Throughout my career, I've taught people of all ages and experience levels. The biggest difference between those who became confident bakers and those who gave up wasn't talent. It was understanding the basics.

That's exactly what this course is designed to do.

We'll start with the foundations: choosing the right equipment, understanding your ingredients, measuring accurately and learning the techniques that make baking both enjoyable and successful.

As your confidence grows, you'll put those skills into practice with delicious recipes that every beginner can master.

Along the way, I'll share practical tips, professional techniques and the little secrets I've learned throughout my years as a chef, helping you avoid common mistakes and achieve better results from the very beginning.

Remember, every cake, every batch of cookies and every loaf teaches you something new.

So put on your apron, preheat your oven and let's start baking together.

Welcome to your baking journey.

Chef Eliane

COURSE GUIDE

How to Get the Most from This Course

Learn in sequence, practise often and treat every result as useful feedback.

This course has been designed to be practical, enjoyable and easy to follow.

Each chapter builds on the previous one, giving you the confidence to develop your baking skills step by step.

Throughout the course you'll discover:

□ Practical baking lessons

Delicious beginner-friendly recipes

Chef's Tips

Kitchen Challenges

Confidence Builders

Rather than rushing through the material, I encourage you to bake along with the course whenever possible. The more you practise, the more natural each technique will become.

Most importantly, don't be afraid to make mistakes.

Every successful baker has had cakes that sank, cookies that spread too much and bread that refused to rise.

Those moments aren't failures; they're part of learning.

By the end of this course you'll have the knowledge and confidence to continue exploring the wonderful world of baking on your own.

PRACTICAL LESSONS Clear foundations that build from one chapter to the next.	BAKE-ALONG RECIPES Sweet and savoury recipes selected to develop real technique.
CHEF'S NOTES Professional guidance focused on the details that affect results.	KITCHEN CHALLENGES Short prompts that turn reading into confident practice.

CHAPTER 1

Building Your Baking Toolkit

Choose dependable essentials and build your collection with purpose.

One of the biggest myths about baking is that you need an expensive kitchen filled with professional equipment before you can produce beautiful results.

You don't.

Some of the most delicious cakes, cookies and breads are made with just a handful of reliable tools and a little patience.

When I first teach beginners, I always encourage them to keep things simple. Invest in quality rather than quantity. As your confidence grows, you can always expand your collection later.

Let's begin with the essentials.

Your Essential Baking Equipment

Digital Kitchen Scale

If I could recommend only one piece of equipment, this would be it.

Unlike everyday cooking, baking relies on precision. Measuring ingredients by weight gives you far more consistent results than using measuring cups alone.

A digital scale quickly becomes one of the most valuable tools in your kitchen.

Measuring Cups and Measuring Spoons

Many recipes, especially those from the United States, use cups and spoons instead of grams.

A complete measuring set allows you to follow recipes accurately and avoid unnecessary guesswork.

Always level dry ingredients with the back of a knife instead of packing them tightly into the cup.

Mixing Bowls

Choose at least three different sizes.

Small bowls are useful for spices and flavourings.

Medium bowls work well for preparing ingredients.

Large bowls give you enough space to comfortably mix cake batters and doughs.

Stainless steel or glass bowls are durable, easy to clean and perfect for everyday baking.

Balloon Whisk

A whisk helps combine ingredients smoothly while incorporating air into mixtures.

It's perfect for beating eggs, preparing batters and making smooth frostings.

Silicone Spatula

A silicone spatula is one of those tools you'll wonder how you ever lived without.

It scrapes every last bit of batter from the bowl and is perfect for gently folding delicate mixtures together.

Wooden Spoon

Sometimes the simplest tools are still the best.

A sturdy wooden spoon is ideal for mixing thicker doughs and cookie mixtures.

Fine Mesh Sieve

Sifting flour may seem old-fashioned, but it removes lumps and helps distribute ingredients more evenly.

It's especially useful when making cakes or dusting desserts with icing sugar.

Rolling Pin

Whether you're making biscuits, pastry or pie dough, a good rolling pin allows you to roll dough evenly without applying too much pressure.

Cooling Rack

Never underestimate this simple piece of equipment.

Allowing baked goods to cool on a wire rack prevents condensation from forming underneath, keeping cakes and cookies light rather than soggy.

Cake Tins and Baking Trays

You don't need every shape imaginable.

A few good-quality tins are more than enough to begin.

I recommend:

One loaf tin

One round cake tin

One muffin tin

Two baking trays

These four items will allow you to prepare almost every recipe in this course.

Baking Paper

Using baking paper makes cleanup easier and helps prevent sticking.

It's one of those inexpensive kitchen essentials you'll use again and again.

Oven Thermometer

Did you know that many domestic ovens are not completely accurate?

An inexpensive oven thermometer helps ensure you're baking at the correct temperature and can dramatically improve your results.

Kitchen Timer

Even experienced chefs use timers.

While experience teaches you what baked goods should look like, a timer prevents distractions from turning beautifully baked cookies into burnt ones.

Building Your Collection

As you continue baking, you may decide to add a few extra tools to your kitchen.

These aren't essential for beginners, but they're wonderful additions once you've gained confidence.

Offset spatula

Bench scraper

Cookie scoop

Piping bags

Decorating nozzles

Cake turntable

Remember, there's no need to buy everything at once.

Build your collection gradually and invest in pieces you'll use for years.

Chef Eliane's Kitchen Wisdom

One question I'm often asked is:

"Do I need expensive equipment to bake well?"

My answer is always the same.

No.

Quality ingredients, careful measuring and patience will improve your baking far more than owning dozens of gadgets.

Learn the basics first.

Everything else can come later.

CHAPTER 1

Kitchen Challenge

Let's see what you've learned.

1. Which piece of equipment would I recommend buying first?

A. Stand mixer

B. Digital kitchen scale

C. Food processor

D. Cake turntable

Answer: B

A digital kitchen scale gives you the most consistent baking results.

2. Why should cakes cool on a wire rack?

A. They cool faster.

B. They become sweeter.

C. Air circulates underneath, preventing a soggy base.

D. They rise higher.

Answer: C

3. True or False

You need expensive equipment before you can become a good baker.

False

Beautiful baking comes from understanding good technique, not owning the most expensive gadgets.

4. Spot the Shopping Mistake

Maria has just started baking.

She buys:

Three different stand mixers.

Fifteen cake tins.

A chocolate fountain.

No digital kitchen scale.

What was her biggest mistake?

She spent her budget on equipment she doesn't yet need instead of investing in the essentials.

Confidence Builder

You've just completed your first chapter.

You now know exactly which tools are essential and which ones can wait until later.

You're already thinking like a baker.

CHAPTER 2

Understanding Your Baking Ingredients

Learn what each ingredient contributes to flavour, texture, structure and lift.

One of the things I enjoy most about baking is that every ingredient has a purpose. Unlike everyday cooking, where you can often improvise, baking is a little more like chemistry. Each ingredient plays its own role, and together they create something wonderful.

The good news? You don't need to become a scientist.

Once you understand what each ingredient does, recipes become much easier to follow, and you'll feel more confident making substitutions when needed.

Let's meet the stars of every baker's pantry.

Flour - The Foundation of Baking

Flour provides the structure that holds your baked goods together.

Different flours contain different amounts of protein, which affects how much gluten develops during mixing. More gluten creates a stronger, chewier texture, while less gluten produces lighter, softer cakes.

All-Purpose Flour

If you're stocking your pantry for the first time, this is the flour to buy.

It's incredibly versatile and works well for cakes, cookies, muffins, pancakes and quick breads.

Bread Flour

Bread flour contains more protein, making it ideal for yeast breads, pizza dough and rolls that need a chewy texture.

Cake Flour

Cake flour has a lower protein content, producing wonderfully soft and delicate cakes with a fine crumb.

Whole Wheat Flour

Made from the whole grain, this flour has a richer flavour and contains more fibre.

Because it's heavier than white flour, many recipes combine it with all-purpose flour for a lighter result.

Self-Raising Flour

This flour already contains baking powder and a little salt.

Always check your recipe before using it, as adding extra baking powder can affect the final result.

Sugar - More Than Sweetness

Many beginners think sugar simply makes cakes sweet.

It actually does much more.

Sugar helps create a beautiful golden colour, keeps cakes moist, improves texture and even helps trap air during mixing, resulting in lighter cakes.

Different sugars also create different flavours.

- White sugar produces a clean, sweet flavour.
- Brown sugar adds moisture and a gentle caramel note.
- Icing sugar is perfect for frostings, buttercream and glazes.

Butter

Butter adds flavour that simply can't be replaced.

It creates tender cakes, crisp biscuits and beautifully flaky pastries.

Whenever a recipe asks for softened butter, leave it at room temperature until it's soft enough to press gently with your finger.

Soft butter creams beautifully with sugar, creating tiny air pockets that help cakes rise.

Oils

Oil creates exceptionally moist cakes that stay fresh for longer.

Unlike butter, it remains liquid even after baking, which is why many loaf cakes and muffins are wonderfully soft for several days.

Eggs

Eggs are one of the hardest-working ingredients in baking.

They bind ingredients together, add moisture, provide richness and help baked goods hold their shape.

Whenever possible, use room-temperature eggs.

They combine more easily with the other ingredients and create a smoother batter.

Chef's Tip

Forgot to remove your eggs from the fridge?

Place them in a bowl of warm water for 10 minutes.

Problem solved.

Baking Powder

Baking powder helps cakes, muffins and quick breads rise.

Because it already contains both the acid and the raising agent, it begins working as soon as it comes into contact with liquid and heat.

Always check the expiry date.

Old baking powder loses its strength and can leave your cakes disappointingly flat.

Baking Soda

Although it looks similar, baking soda works differently.

It needs an acidic ingredient such as yoghurt, buttermilk, vinegar or lemon juice before it can create lift.

Never substitute one for the other unless the recipe specifically tells you how.

Salt

Even sweet recipes benefit from a small pinch of salt.

Salt balances sweetness and enhances the flavour of every other ingredient.

A cake without salt can taste surprisingly flat.

Vanilla

Vanilla is often called the background flavour of baking.

You may not always notice it, but you'd certainly miss it if it weren't there.

Whenever possible, choose pure vanilla extract for the best flavour.

Chocolate

Not all chocolate is created equal.

Higher-quality chocolate melts more smoothly and produces richer flavour in cakes, brownies and desserts.

For the best results, choose chocolate you would also enjoy eating on its own.

Dairy Products

Milk, cream, yoghurt and buttermilk all contribute moisture and richness.

Buttermilk and yoghurt also add acidity, which helps activate baking soda and produces beautifully soft cakes.

Building Your Pantry

When you're just starting out, there's no need to buy every baking ingredient available.

A simple pantry will allow you to prepare dozens of delicious recipes.

My Beginner's Pantry

All-purpose flour

White sugar

Brown sugar

Baking powder

Baking soda

Fine sea salt

Vanilla extract

Unsalted butter

Vegetable oil

Eggs

Milk

Cocoa powder

Dark chocolate

With these ingredients alone, you'll be able to bake a wonderful variety of cakes, cookies, muffins and brownies.

Chef Eliane's Kitchen Wisdom

When I teach beginners, I always encourage them to read the ingredient list before they start baking.

Understanding why each ingredient is there is just as important as knowing how much to use.

As your confidence grows, you'll find yourself looking at recipes in a completely different way, not just following instructions, but understanding the science behind them.

CHAPTER 2

Kitchen Challenge

1. Which flour is the best all-round choice for beginner bakers?

   A. Bread flour

   B. Cake flour

   C. All-purpose flour

   D. Whole wheat flour

Answer: C

2. Why should butter often be softened before baking?

   A. It tastes sweeter.

   B. It mixes more easily with sugar, creating a lighter batter.

   C. It melts faster.

   D. It makes cakes bake quicker.

Answer: B

3. True or False

Baking soda and baking powder always do exactly the same job.

False

Although both help baked goods rise, they work differently and aren't always interchangeable.

4. Spot the Baking Mistake

Emma wants to bake a cake.

She uses baking soda but forgets to include the yoghurt called for in the recipe.

What could happen?

Without an acidic ingredient, the baking soda won't work properly, and the cake may not rise as expected.

Confidence Builder

Congratulations!

You now understand the purpose of the ingredients you'll use in almost every baking recipe.

From this point onward, you'll begin baking with understanding rather than simply following instructions, and that's a wonderful step towards becoming a confident baker.

CHAPTER 3

Measuring Like a Baker

Accuracy turns a good recipe into a result you can repeat.

Have you ever followed a recipe exactly, only to wonder why your cake looked nothing like the picture?

Very often, the answer comes down to one simple thing: measuring.

Unlike everyday cooking, baking depends on accuracy. A little too much flour, too little baking powder, or an extra splash of milk can completely change the final result.

The good news is that measuring correctly is easy once you develop a few good habits.

Why Accuracy Matters

Think of a baking recipe as a team.

Every ingredient has an important role to play.

Too much flour can make cakes dry and heavy.

Too much sugar may cause cookies to spread too much.

Too much baking powder can leave an unpleasant aftertaste or make cakes rise quickly before collapsing.

Getting the measurements right gives every ingredient the best chance to do its job.

Weighing vs Measuring

Professional bakers almost always weigh their ingredients.

Why?

Because 250 grams of flour is always 250 grams.

A cup of flour, however, can vary considerably depending on how it's scooped or packed.

That's why I encourage you to use a digital kitchen scale whenever possible.

It removes the guesswork and gives you beautifully consistent results every time.

Measuring Dry Ingredients

When using measuring cups:

- Spoon the flour gently into the cup.
- Never scoop directly from the bag.
- Level the top with the back of a knife.

Packing flour tightly into the cup can add far more flour than the recipe intended.

Measuring Liquids

Liquid ingredients should be measured in a clear measuring jug placed on a flat surface.

Always check the measurement at eye level.

Looking from above or below can easily lead to inaccurate measurements.

Measuring Sticky Ingredients

Honey, syrup and molasses have a habit of sticking to everything.

Here's a little trick I use.

Lightly coat your measuring spoon or cup with a tiny amount of neutral oil before measuring.

The sticky ingredient slides straight out.

Simple, but very effective.

Room Temperature Ingredients

Many recipes ask for room-temperature butter, eggs or milk.

There's a good reason for this.

Cold ingredients don't combine as smoothly and can cause batters to separate.

Whenever possible, remove refrigerated ingredients about 30 minutes before you begin baking.

Read the Recipe First

One of the best habits you can develop is reading the entire recipe before you start.

It sounds obvious, but you'd be surprised how many people discover halfway through that they forgot to soften the butter or preheat the oven.

A quick read-through helps you prepare everything in advance and makes the whole baking process much more relaxed.

Organise Before You Begin

Professional kitchens work according to a simple principle called mise en place, which means "everything in its place."

Before you start mixing:

- Measure every ingredient.
- Prepare your baking tins.
- Preheat the oven.
- Gather your equipment.

When everything is ready, baking becomes calm, organised and much more enjoyable.

Understanding Oven Temperatures

Every oven behaves a little differently.

Some run hotter than the temperature displayed, while others take longer to heat.

That's why I always recommend preheating your oven fully before placing anything inside.

Opening the oven door too often allows heat to escape and can affect how your cakes rise.

Patience is one of the secret ingredients in successful baking.

Chef Eliane's Kitchen Wisdom

One of the best pieces of advice I can give you is this:

Don't rush.

Take five extra minutes to measure your ingredients carefully.

Those few minutes often make the difference between an average bake and one you're proud to share with family and friends.

Baking rewards patience.

CHAPTER 3

Kitchen Challenge

1. Which method gives the most accurate baking results?

A. Guessing

B. Measuring by eye

C. Using a digital kitchen scale

D. Using the biggest measuring cup

Answer: C

2. True or False

You should scoop flour directly from the bag with your measuring cup.

False

Spooning flour into the cup creates a much more accurate measurement.

3. Spot the Baking Mistake

David decides to bake a cake.

He forgets to preheat the oven, uses cold butter straight from the fridge and estimates the flour without measuring.

Can you identify the three mistakes?

The oven wasn't preheated.

The butter was too cold.

The flour wasn't measured accurately.

4. Which ingredients are usually best used at room temperature?

A. Butter and eggs

B. Ice cubes

C. Frozen fruit

D. Chocolate chips

Answer: A

Confidence Builder

You're beginning to think like a baker.

From now on, you'll understand that successful baking starts before the mixing bowl comes out. Careful preparation, accurate measuring and a little patience are the habits that turn good recipes into consistently delicious results.

CHAPTER 4

Mastering the Essential Mixing Techniques

Cream, whisk, fold, stir and knead with a clear purpose.

If you've ever wondered why one cake is beautifully light while another turns out heavy and dense, the answer often lies in how the ingredients were mixed.

Mixing isn't simply about combining ingredients. Each method has a purpose, and choosing the right one can make a remarkable difference to the finished bake.

The good news is that there are only a handful of techniques every beginner needs to learn.

Once you've mastered these, you'll use them again and again throughout your baking journey.

Creaming

Creaming is one of the most important techniques in baking.

It involves beating softened butter and sugar together until the mixture becomes pale, light and fluffy.

During this process, tiny air bubbles are trapped in the butter. These air bubbles expand during baking, helping cakes become lighter and softer.

Take your time. Proper creaming usually takes three to five minutes.

Chef Tip

If your butter is too cold, it won't cream properly. If it's melted, it won't trap enough air.

Softened butter should feel similar to pressing gently on a ripe peach.

Whisking

Whisking adds air to ingredients.

Whether you're beating eggs, whipping cream or preparing a smooth batter, whisking creates volume and lightness.

For best results, use a balloon whisk or an electric mixer.

Folding

Folding is one of the gentlest mixing techniques.

Instead of stirring vigorously, use a spatula to lift the mixture from the bottom of the bowl and gently fold it over itself.

This preserves the air you've worked so hard to create.

You'll often use folding when making sponge cakes, mousses and whipped cream.

Stirring

Stirring is the simplest mixing method.

Its purpose is simply to combine ingredients evenly without adding unnecessary air.

A wooden spoon or silicone spatula works perfectly.

Kneading

Kneading develops gluten in bread dough, giving bread its wonderful structure and chewy texture.

Unlike cake batter, bread dough actually benefits from being worked.

As you knead, the dough gradually becomes smoother, softer and more elastic.

The Biggest Beginner Mistake

- One mistake appears again and again in beginner baking.
- Overmixing.
- Many people believe that mixing longer automatically creates better results.
- The opposite is usually true.
- Once the flour has been incorporated, stop mixing unless the recipe says otherwise.
- Overmixing develops too much gluten and often produces heavy cakes, tough muffins and dense quick breads.

Chef Eliane's Kitchen Wisdom

Whenever I'm teaching beginners, I remind them of one simple rule:

Mix with purpose.

Each recipe tells you how much mixing is needed.

Trust the recipe, and stop when it's ready.

Your cakes will reward you.

CHAPTER 4

Kitchen Challenge

Which technique should you use when adding whipped cream to a mousse?

A. Kneading

B. Folding

C. Creaming

D. Stirring vigorously

Answer: B

True or False

The longer you mix cake batter, the lighter your cake will become.

False.

Too much mixing develops gluten and creates a heavier cake.

Spot the Mistake

James keeps mixing his muffin batter for ten minutes because he wants it perfectly smooth.

What could happen?

His muffins may become dense and tough instead of light and tender.

Confidence Builder

You've just learned one of the biggest professional baking secrets:

Knowing when to stop mixing.

Sometimes doing less produces the best results.

CHAPTER 5

Understanding Your Oven

Use heat, timing and visual cues to recognise a perfectly finished bake.

Your oven is your baking partner.

Even the best recipe can't produce beautiful results if the oven isn't working with you.

Every oven behaves a little differently.

Some bake hotter.

Others bake cooler.

Learning how your own oven performs is one of the fastest ways to improve your baking.

Always Preheat

Never place cakes or cookies into a cold oven unless the recipe specifically tells you to.

Preheating ensures the batter begins baking immediately, giving baked goods the proper rise and texture.

Fan or Conventional?

Many modern ovens have both settings.

A fan oven circulates hot air, baking more evenly and often slightly faster.

A conventional oven heats from the top and bottom and may require rotating baking trays halfway through.

If your recipe gives only one temperature, check whether it's written for a fan or conventional oven.

Oven Shelves

Believe it or not, where you place your baking tray matters.

The middle shelf is ideal for most cakes, cookies and muffins because the heat circulates evenly around the bake.

The lower shelf is better for bread and pizza, while the upper shelf is generally used for grilling or browning.

Resist Opening the Door

This is probably the hardest lesson for beginners.

It's tempting to keep checking your cake.

But every time you open the oven, the temperature drops.

That sudden loss of heat can cause delicate cakes to sink.

Whenever possible, use the oven light and window instead.

Knowing When It's Done

Time is only a guide.

Your eyes are often the best judge.

Look for:

- A golden colour.
- A springy surface.
- A clean skewer or toothpick.
- The delicious aroma of freshly baked goods filling your kitchen.

These signs are often more reliable than the timer alone.

Chef Eliane's Kitchen Wisdom

One of the biggest differences between beginners and experienced bakers isn't talent.

Experienced bakers learn to trust what they see.

Colour, aroma and texture tell you just as much as the clock.

Chef's Secret: Keep Puff Pastry Cold

Puff pastry gets its incredible light, flaky layers from thin sheets of butter trapped between layers of dough.

As the pastry bakes, the butter creates steam that lifts the layers apart.

If the pastry becomes warm before baking, the butter begins to soften and melt into the dough. The pastry becomes sticky, difficult to handle and won't rise as beautifully in the oven.

For the best results:

- Keep the pastry refrigerated until you're ready to use it.
- Work quickly on a lightly floured surface.
- If it starts to feel soft, return it to the refrigerator for 10-15 minutes before continuing.

It's a simple habit that makes a big difference.

CHAPTER 5

Kitchen Challenge

Where should most cakes be baked?

A. Top shelf

B. Middle shelf

C. Bottom shelf

D. It doesn't matter.

Answer: B

True or False

Opening the oven every five minutes helps cakes bake more evenly.

False.

It causes the oven temperature to drop and can affect the rise.

Spot the Baking Mistake

Emma checks her sponge cake six times during baking.

The cake sinks in the middle.

Can you guess why?

Constantly opening the oven door allowed too much heat to escape.

Confidence Builder

Congratulations!

You now understand how to work with your oven instead of against it. That knowledge alone will improve almost every bake you make.

CHAPTER 6

Bake Along with Chef Eliane

Put the foundations into practice through five sweet bakes, five savoury bakes and a Greek bonus recipe.

Now it's time to put everything you've learned into practice.

Throughout the first part of this course, you've built a solid foundation. You now understand your ingredients, know how to measure accurately, have learned the essential mixing techniques and have discovered how to get the best from your oven.

The recipes in this chapter have been carefully chosen to help you build your confidence one bake at a time. Each one introduces a new technique while remaining approachable for beginners. We'll move from simple batters and rustic pastries to yeast doughs, savoury bakes and classic French choux pastry.

Don't worry if everything isn't perfect the first time. Every baker, including me, has had cakes that didn't rise quite enough or pastry that wasn't as neat as planned. That's all part of learning.

The most important ingredient you can bring to your kitchen is curiosity. Take your time, enjoy the process and celebrate every success along the way.

So, put on your apron, preheat the oven and let's start baking together.

Sweet Bakes	Savoury Bakes
Dutch Baby Pancake Apple Tarte Tatin Rustic Peach Galette Lemon Yogurt Cake Chocolate Brownies	Rosemary Focaccia Coca de Trempó French Gougères Goat Cheese & Onion Tart Empanada de Atún

CHAPTER 6

Sweet Bakes

Five confidence-building recipes, from a dramatic Dutch Baby to rich chocolate brownies.

SWEET BAKES | RECIPE 01

Dutch Baby Pancake

A spectacular bake with surprisingly little effort

One of the things I love most about a Dutch Baby is the little bit of magic that happens in the oven. A simple batter transforms into a beautifully puffed pancake with crisp golden edges and a soft, custardy centre. It's one of those recipes that always impresses, yet couldn't be easier to make.

Whether you're serving it for a relaxed weekend breakfast, brunch with friends or a simple dessert topped with seasonal fruit, this recipe is a wonderful introduction to baking.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
4	10 minutes	20-25 minutes

EQUIPMENT

- 25 cm (10-inch) ovenproof skillet or cast-iron pan
- Mixing bowl
- Whisk
- Measuring jug

INGREDIENTS

- 3 large eggs, room temperature
- 180 ml whole milk, room temperature
- 65 g all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- Pinch of fine sea salt
- 30 g unsalted butter

To serve (optional)

- Fresh berries
- Sliced peaches
- Lemon wedges
- Icing sugar
- Maple syrup or honey

Method

01 Preheat your oven to 220°C (425°F) and place the empty skillet inside while the oven heats.

02 In a bowl, whisk together the eggs, milk and vanilla until smooth.

03 Add the flour and salt, whisking until no lumps remain. Don't worry if the batter seems thin; that's exactly what you want.

04 Carefully remove the hot skillet from the oven and add the butter. Swirl it around until melted and coating the base.

05 Immediately pour the batter into the hot pan and return it to the oven.

06 Bake for 20-25 minutes, until the pancake is deeply golden, puffed around the edges and lightly browned.

07 Remove from the oven and serve immediately with your favourite toppings.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Room-temperature eggs and milk help create a higher rise.

A properly preheated pan is the secret to those dramatic puffed edges.

Resist opening the oven while it's baking or the pancake may lose some of its height.

A Dutch Baby naturally settles after a few minutes; that's perfectly normal.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Preparing a smooth batter
- Why preheating the pan matters
- How steam creates lift
- Recognising when a bake is perfectly done

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Next time, try a different topping.
[ ] Fresh berries
[ ] Caramelised apples
[ ] Peaches and honey
[ ] Lemon and icing sugar
[ ] Mixed seasonal fruit

SWEET BAKES | RECIPE 02

Puff Pastry Apple Tarte Tatin

A French classic made beautifully simple

One of the things I love most about this recipe is that it proves elegant baking doesn't have to be complicated. With buttery puff pastry, caramelised apples and just a handful of pantry ingredients, you can create a dessert that looks as though it came straight from a French pâtisserie.

It's the perfect recipe for beginner bakers because it introduces one of the most versatile ingredients you'll ever use: puff pastry.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
6	20 minutes	30-35 minutes

Puff Pastry Apple Tarte Tatin

EQUIPMENT

- 24 cm (9-10 inch) ovenproof frying pan or tarte tatin pan
- Peeler
- Sharp knife
- Wooden spoon

INGREDIENTS

- 1 sheet all-butter puff pastry
- 4-5 firm apples (Golden Delicious, Braeburn or Pink Lady)
- 60 g unsalted butter
- 80 g caster sugar
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon (optional)
- Pinch of sea salt

To serve

- Crème fraîche
- Vanilla ice cream
- Lightly whipped cream

Method

01 Remove the puff pastry from the refrigerator only when you're ready to use it.

02 Peel, core and cut the apples into thick wedges.

03 Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F).

04 In an ovenproof frying pan, melt the butter over medium heat.

05 Add the sugar and cook gently until it begins to caramelise and turns a light golden colour.

06 Stir in the vanilla and, if using, the cinnamon.

07 Arrange the apple wedges neatly in the caramel, packing them quite tightly as they will shrink during baking.

08 Cook for about 10 minutes until the apples begin to soften.

09 Lay the puff pastry over the apples, tucking the edges down around the fruit.

10 Pierce the pastry a few times with a fork to allow steam to escape.

11 Bake for 25-30 minutes, until the pastry is deeply golden and crisp.

12 Leave the tart to rest for 5 minutes.

13 Carefully place a serving plate over the pan and, using oven gloves, confidently invert the tart onto the plate.

14 Serve warm with crème fraîche or vanilla ice cream.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Keep Puff Pastry Cold

Puff pastry gets its beautiful flaky layers from hundreds of thin layers of butter folded into the dough.

If the pastry becomes warm before baking, the butter starts to soften and melt. This makes the pastry sticky, harder to handle and prevents it from rising properly in the oven.

For the best results:

Keep puff pastry refrigerated until the moment you need it.

Work quickly on a lightly floured surface.

If it becomes soft while you're working, place it back in the refrigerator for 10-15 minutes before continuing.

It's a simple habit that makes all the difference.

Don't Rush the Caramel

The caramel should be a light golden colour. If it becomes too dark, it can develop a bitter flavour that overpowers the sweetness of the apples.

Be Confident When Turning the Tart

Once you've placed the serving plate on top, invert the tart in one smooth movement. A little confidence goes a long way!

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Working with ready-made puff pastry
- Keeping pastry cold for the best results
- Making a simple caramel
- Arranging fruit for an attractive finish
- Baking until perfectly crisp and golden

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Next time, why not try a different fruit?
[ ] Pears
[ ] Peaches
[ ] Apricots
[ ] Plums
[ ] Mixed apples and pears

SWEET BAKES | RECIPE 03

Rustic Peach Galette

A beautifully imperfect French classic

One of the things I love most about a galette is that it celebrates simplicity. Unlike a traditional tart, there are no perfect edges or intricate patterns to worry about. The beauty of a galette lies in its rustic appearance, where juicy seasonal fruit is wrapped in crisp, buttery pastry and baked until golden.

This is the perfect recipe for building your confidence with pastry. Remember, rustic is exactly how it's meant to look.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
6	30 minutes (+ 30 minutes chilling)	35-40 minutes

Rustic Peach Galette

EQUIPMENT

- Mixing bowl
- Rolling pin
- Baking tray
- Baking paper
- Pastry brush

INGREDIENTS

For the pastry

- 250 g all-purpose flour
- ½ tsp fine sea salt
- 170 g cold unsalted butter, diced
- 60-80 ml iced water

For the filling

- 4 ripe but firm peaches
- 40 g caster sugar
- 1 tbsp cornflour
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- ½ tsp ground cinnamon (optional)
- 1 tsp lemon zest

To finish

- 1 egg, beaten
- 1 tbsp coarse sugar (optional)

Method

01 In a large bowl, combine the flour and salt.

02 Rub the cold butter into the flour until the mixture resembles coarse breadcrumbs.

03 Gradually add the iced water until the dough just comes together.

04 Shape into a disc, wrap and refrigerate for at least 30 minutes.

05 Preheat the oven to 190°C (375°F).

06 Slice the peaches and mix them with the sugar, cornflour, vanilla, cinnamon and lemon zest.

07 Roll the chilled pastry into a rough 30 cm circle on a lightly floured surface.

08 Transfer it to a baking tray lined with baking paper.

09 Spoon the peaches into the centre, leaving a 5 cm border.

10 Fold the edges of the pastry over the fruit, allowing the folds to overlap naturally.

11 Brush the pastry with beaten egg and sprinkle with coarse sugar.

12 Bake for 35-40 minutes, until the pastry is crisp and golden and the peaches are bubbling.

13 Allow the galette to cool slightly before serving.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Cold Butter Is Your Best Friend

Cold butter creates tiny pockets throughout the pastry. As it bakes, the butter melts and creates steam, producing those beautiful flaky layers.

Don't Worry About Perfection

One of the charms of a galette is its rustic look. Uneven folds and imperfect edges are part of its character.

Choose Firm Peaches

Very soft peaches release too much juice and can make the pastry soggy.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Making a simple pastry dough
- Why ingredients should stay cold
- Rolling pastry evenly
- Folding a rustic galette
- Using an egg wash for a golden finish

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Which fruit will you try next?
[ ] Apricots
[ ] Plums
[ ] Pears
[ ] Apples
[ ] Mixed berries

SWEET BAKES | RECIPE 04

Lemon Yogurt Cake

Sunshine in Every Slice

Simple, moist and full of fresh lemon flavour, this is one of those cakes you'll come back to time and time again. It's perfect with a cup of coffee, for afternoon tea or as a light dessert with fresh berries.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
8	15 minutes	40-45 minutes

Lemon Yogurt Cake

EQUIPMENT

- 23 cm (9-inch) loaf tin or round cake tin
- Mixing bowls
- Electric mixer or whisk
- Cooling rack

INGREDIENTS

- 200 g all-purpose flour
- 2 tsp baking powder
- ¼ tsp salt
- 200 g caster sugar
- 2 large eggs
- 180 g Greek yogurt
- 120 ml vegetable oil
- Zest of 2 lemons
- 2 tbsp fresh lemon juice
- 1 tsp vanilla extract

Lemon Glaze

- 100 g icing sugar
- 2-3 tbsp lemon juice

Method

01 Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F). Grease and line your cake tin.

02 Whisk together the flour, baking powder and salt.

03 In another bowl, beat the eggs and sugar until pale.

04 Add the yogurt, oil, vanilla, lemon zest and juice.

05 Fold in the dry ingredients until just combined.

06 Pour into the prepared tin.

07 Bake for 40-45 minutes, until a skewer comes out clean.

08 Cool for 15 minutes before removing from the tin.

09 Mix the glaze ingredients and drizzle over the cooled cake.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Don't overmix once the flour has been added.

Fresh lemon zest gives far more flavour than bottled extracts.

Allow the cake to cool before glazing.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Beating and folding techniques
- Preparing a cake tin
- Testing for doneness
- Making a simple glaze

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Replace lemon with orange zest
[ ] Try lime zest and juice
[ ] Serve with fresh berries

SWEET BAKES | RECIPE 05

Classic Chocolate Brownies

Rich, Fudgy and Impossible to Resist

A great brownie should have a delicate crust on top and a rich, fudgy centre. This recipe is wonderfully simple and teaches an important lesson: sometimes less mixing creates better results.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
12	15 minutes	25-30 minutes

Classic Chocolate Brownies

EQUIPMENT

- 20 cm (8-inch) square tin
- Heatproof bowl
- Mixing bowl
- Spatula
- Baking paper

INGREDIENTS

- 200 g dark chocolate
- 170 g unsalted butter
- 200 g caster sugar
- 3 eggs
- 100 g all-purpose flour
- 30 g cocoa powder
- ½ tsp salt
- 1 tsp vanilla

Method

01 Preheat oven to 180°C (350°F).

02 Melt the butter and chocolate together.

03 Stir in the sugar.

04 Add the eggs one at a time.

05 Mix in the vanilla.

06 Fold in the flour, cocoa and salt.

07 Pour into a lined 20 cm square tin.

08 Bake for 25-30 minutes.

09 Cool completely before slicing.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Slightly underbaked brownies stay wonderfully fudgy.

Cooling completely makes cutting much easier.

Use good-quality dark chocolate.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Melting chocolate
- Folding ingredients
- Recognising a fudgy bake
- Cooling before slicing

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Add toasted walnuts
[ ] Fold in dark chocolate chunks
[ ] Compare a 25-minute and 30-minute bake

CHAPTER 6

Savoury Bakes

Mediterranean and French favourites that introduce yeast, choux and savoury pastry.

SAVOURY BAKES | RECIPE 06

Italian No-Knead Rosemary Focaccia

The Bread That Builds Confidence

Few things are more satisfying than baking your own bread. This no-knead focaccia is wonderfully forgiving and rewards you with a crisp crust, a soft airy crumb and the irresistible aroma of rosemary and olive oil.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
8	20 minutes (+ rising)	25-30 minutes

Italian No-Knead Rosemary Focaccia

EQUIPMENT

- Large mixing bowl
- Wooden spoon or dough scraper
- 23 x 33 cm baking tray
- Plastic wrap or tea towel

INGREDIENTS

- 500 g bread flour
- 7 g instant dried yeast (1 sachet)
- 10 g fine sea salt
- 400 ml lukewarm water
- 3 tbsp extra virgin olive oil, plus extra for drizzling
- 2 tbsp fresh rosemary leaves
- Flaky sea salt

Method

01 In a large bowl, combine the flour, yeast and salt.

02 Add the lukewarm water and olive oil. Stir until no dry flour remains. The dough will be soft and sticky.

03 Cover with a tea towel or plastic wrap and leave to rise for about 2 hours, or until doubled in size.

04 Generously oil your baking tray and transfer the dough to the tray.

05 Gently stretch the dough towards the corners without forcing it. If it springs back, let it rest for 10 minutes before stretching again.

06 Cover and leave to rise for another 30-45 minutes.

07 Preheat the oven to 220°C (425°F).

08 Drizzle generously with olive oil and press your fingertips into the dough to create the characteristic dimples.

09 Scatter over the rosemary and sprinkle with flaky sea salt.

10 Bake for 25-30 minutes, until deeply golden.

11 Cool slightly before slicing.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

A wet dough creates an airy focaccia.

Be generous with olive oil.

Press your fingertips firmly to create the classic dimples.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Working with yeast
- Dough fermentation
- High-hydration dough
- Dimpling focaccia

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Next time, try one of these toppings:
[ ] Cherry tomatoes
[ ] Black olives
[ ] Thinly sliced red onion
[ ] Fresh thyme
[ ] Roasted garlic

SAVOURY BAKES | RECIPE 07

Coca de Trempó

A Taste of Mallorca

Fresh vegetables, olive oil and a crisp homemade base make this traditional Majorcan bake one of the Mediterranean's hidden gems.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
6-8	30 minutes (+ 45-60 minutes resting)	30-35 minutes

Coca de Trempó

EQUIPMENT

- Large mixing bowl
- Rolling pin
- Large baking tray
- Baking paper (Parchment)

INGREDIENTS

For the dough

- 500 g all-purpose flour
- 7 g instant dried yeast
- 250 ml lukewarm water
- 80 ml extra virgin olive oil
- 1 tsp fine sea salt

For the topping

- 2 ripe tomatoes, diced
- 1 green bell pepper, diced
- 1 red bell pepper, diced
- 1 medium onion, finely diced
- 2 tbsp extra virgin olive oil
- Salt and freshly ground black pepper

Method

01 Combine the flour, yeast and salt in a large bowl.

02 Add the water and olive oil and mix until a soft dough forms.

03 Knead for about 8 minutes until smooth and elastic.

04 Cover and allow the dough to rest for 45-60 minutes.

05 Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F).

06 Mix the tomatoes, peppers, onion, olive oil, salt and pepper in a bowl.

07 Roll the dough into a thin rectangle and place it on a baking tray lined with baking paper.

08 Spread the vegetable mixture evenly over the dough, leaving a small border.

09 Bake for 30-35 minutes, until the edges are crisp and golden.

10 Allow to cool slightly before cutting into squares.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Dice the vegetables evenly so they cook at the same rate.

If your tomatoes are particularly juicy, drain them for a few minutes before using to keep the base crisp.

A drizzle of extra virgin olive oil just before serving adds wonderful flavour.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Making a simple yeast dough
- Rolling dough evenly
- Preparing fresh Mediterranean toppings
- Baking a crisp flatbread

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Try creating your own version.
[ ] Add black olives
[ ] Add anchovies
[ ] Add courgette slices
[ ] Add roasted red peppers
[ ] Add crumbled goat cheese

SAVOURY BAKES | RECIPE 08

French Gougères (Classic Gruyère Cheese Puffs)

Light, Airy and Wonderfully French

Gougères are one of France's most beloved savoury bakes. Made with choux pastry and plenty of Gruyère cheese, they're crisp on the outside, light inside and delicious served warm. They're perfect as an aperitif, alongside soup or as part of a cheese board.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
20-24 gougères	25 minutes	25-30 minutes

French Gougères (Classic Gruyère Cheese Puffs)

EQUIPMENT

- Medium saucepan
- Wooden spoon
- Mixing bowl
- Baking tray
- Baking paper
- Piping bag (optional)

INGREDIENTS

- 125 ml water
- 125 ml whole milk
- 100 g unsalted butter
- ½ tsp fine sea salt
- 150 g all-purpose flour
- 4 large eggs
- 120 g Gruyère cheese, finely grated
- Pinch of freshly ground black pepper
- Pinch of nutmeg (optional)

Method

01 Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F). Line two baking trays with baking paper.

02 In a saucepan, bring the water, milk, butter and salt to a gentle boil.

03 Remove from the heat and add the flour all at once. Stir vigorously until the mixture forms a smooth ball.

04 Return to a low heat for 1-2 minutes, stirring continuously to dry the dough slightly.

05 Transfer to a bowl and allow to cool for 5 minutes.

06 Add the eggs one at a time, beating well after each addition until smooth and glossy.

07 Fold in the Gruyère, pepper and nutmeg.

08 Pipe or spoon walnut-sized mounds onto the baking trays.

09 Bake for 25-30 minutes until puffed and deeply golden.

10 Serve warm.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Don't open the oven during baking or the gougères may collapse.

The dough should be smooth and glossy before adding the cheese.

Freshly grated Gruyère melts much better than pre-grated cheese.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Making choux pastry
- Adding eggs correctly
- Steam-leavened baking
- Piping or spooning batter

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Add finely chopped chives
[ ] Try Comté in place of Gruyère
[ ] Serve warm with soup

SAVOURY BAKES | RECIPE 09

French Goat Cheese, Caramelised Onion & Thyme Tart

Elegant French Baking Made Simple

Sweet caramelised onions, creamy goat cheese and fragrant thyme come together in a tart that's simple enough for a weekday lunch yet elegant enough to serve when entertaining.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
6	25 minutes	30-35 minutes

French Goat Cheese, Caramelised Onion & Thyme Tart

EQUIPMENT

- Baking tray
- Frying pan
- Baking paper

INGREDIENTS

- 1 sheet all-butter puff pastry
- 3 large onions, thinly sliced
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 tbsp butter
- 1 tsp brown sugar
- 150 g soft goat cheese
- 1 tsp fresh thyme leaves
- 1 egg, beaten
- Salt and freshly ground black pepper

Method

01 Preheat the oven to 200°C (400°F).

02 Heat the olive oil and butter in a frying pan. Add the onions and cook over low heat for 20-25 minutes until soft and caramelised.

03 Stir in the brown sugar during the last few minutes of cooking.

04 Roll out the puff pastry slightly and place it on a lined baking tray.

05 Score a 2 cm border around the edge without cutting through the pastry.

06 Spread the caramelised onions over the centre.

07 Crumble the goat cheese on top and sprinkle with thyme.

08 Brush the border with beaten egg.

09 Bake for 30-35 minutes until the pastry is crisp and golden.

10 Serve warm or at room temperature.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Keep the puff pastry chilled until you're ready to use it.

Low and slow is the secret to beautifully caramelised onions.

A drizzle of honey before serving is delicious if you enjoy a sweet-savoury combination.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Caramelising onions
- Working with puff pastry
- Creating a rustic savoury tart
- Balancing sweet and savoury flavours

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Finish with a light drizzle of honey
[ ] Add sliced pear
[ ] Try rosemary in place of thyme

SAVOURY BAKES | RECIPE 10

Spanish Empanada de Atún

A Spanish Favourite for Any Occasion

Empanada de Atún is a classic throughout Spain. A crisp golden pastry filled with tuna, peppers, onions and tomato makes it ideal for lunch, picnics or sharing with friends and family.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
8	35 minutes	35-40 minutes

Spanish Empanada de Atún

EQUIPMENT

- Rolling pin
- Frying pan
- Baking tray
- Pastry brush

INGREDIENTS

For the pastry
- 500 g all-purpose flour
- 100 ml olive oil
- 150 ml warm water
- 1 tsp salt
- 1 egg

Filling
- 2 tbsp olive oil
- 1 onion, finely chopped
- 1 red bell pepper, diced
- 2 garlic cloves, minced
- 200 g canned tuna, drained
- 150 ml tomato passata
- 1 tsp sweet smoked paprika
- Salt and black pepper

To finish
- 1 egg, beaten

Method

01 Combine the flour and salt. Add the olive oil, warm water and egg, mixing until a smooth dough forms. Cover and let it rest for 30 minutes.

02 Meanwhile, heat the olive oil and gently cook the onion and pepper for 8-10 minutes.

03 Add the garlic and paprika and cook for another minute.

04 Stir in the tomato passata and simmer for 10 minutes.

05 Remove from the heat and fold in the tuna. Allow the filling to cool completely.

06 Preheat the oven to 190°C (375°F).

07 Divide the dough into two pieces. Roll out the first piece and place it on a lined baking tray.

08 Spread the cooled filling over the pastry, leaving a border around the edge.

09 Roll out the second piece of dough and place it over the filling. Seal the edges by pressing with a fork or crimping with your fingers.

10 Brush with beaten egg and cut a small steam hole in the centre.

11 Bake for 35-40 minutes until beautifully golden.

12 Allow to cool slightly before slicing.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Always cool the filling before assembling the empanada to prevent the pastry from becoming soggy.

Don't overfill the pastry or it may split during baking.

Empanada tastes just as delicious served warm or at room temperature.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Preparing a savoury filling
- Making and rolling pastry dough
- Sealing pastry correctly
- Using an egg wash for a golden finish
- Baking until crisp and evenly coloured

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Shape six small hand pies
[ ] Add chopped green olives
[ ] Serve at room temperature for a picnic

BONUS RECIPE

A Greek Celebration

Crisp buttered filo wrapped around smooth vanilla semolina custard.

BONUS RECIPE | RECIPE 11

Traditional Greek Bougatsa

A Sweet Taste of Greece

If you've ever wandered through the streets of Greece in the early morning, you've probably caught the irresistible aroma of freshly baked bougatsa drifting from local bakeries. Delicate, buttery layers of crisp filo pastry wrapped around a silky vanilla custard create one of Greece's most beloved pastries. Served warm with a generous dusting of icing sugar and cinnamon, it's a simple yet unforgettable treat that's perfect for breakfast, brunch or dessert.

SERVES	PREPARATION	BAKING
8	30 minutes	35-40 minutes

Traditional Greek Bougatsa

EQUIPMENT

- 23 x 33 cm baking dish
- Medium saucepan
- Whisk
- Pastry brush
- Mixing bowl

INGREDIENTS

For the custard

- 750 ml whole milk
- 120 g caster sugar
- 90 g fine semolina
- 2 large eggs
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 30 g unsalted butter

For the pastry

- 10 sheets filo pastry
- 150 g unsalted butter, melted

To Finish

- Icing sugar
- Ground cinnamon

Method

01 Preheat the oven to 180°C (350°F).

02 Heat the milk in a saucepan until just below boiling.

03 Gradually whisk in the sugar and semolina. Continue whisking over medium heat until the mixture thickens into a smooth custard.

04 Remove the saucepan from the heat.

05 In a separate bowl, beat the eggs with the vanilla. Gradually whisk in a ladleful of the hot semolina custard to temper the eggs. Slowly whisk the tempered egg mixture back into the remaining custard. Return to low heat for 1-2 minutes, whisking constantly, until smooth and thick. Remove from the heat, stir in the butter, and allow the filling to cool slightly.

06 Brush the baking dish with melted butter.

07 Layer five sheets of filo pastry in the dish, brushing each sheet generously with melted butter before adding the next.

08 Pour the custard evenly over the pastry.

09 Cover with the remaining filo sheets, again brushing each layer with melted butter.

10 Tuck the edges neatly into the baking dish.

11 Lightly score the top with a sharp knife.

12 Bake for 35-40 minutes, until the pastry is crisp, deeply golden and beautifully flaky.

13 Allow the bougatsa to cool for 10 minutes before dusting generously with icing sugar and cinnamon.

14 Serve warm.

Chef Eliane's Secrets

Keep Filo Covered

Filo pastry dries out very quickly. Cover the unused sheets with a slightly damp tea towel while you work to keep them soft and easy to handle.

Butter Every Layer

Brushing each sheet with melted butter creates the beautifully crisp, flaky layers that make bougatsa so irresistible.

Let the Custard Cool Slightly

Adding hot custard to the pastry can soften the layers before baking. Allowing it to cool for a few minutes helps keep the pastry crisp.

Bougatsa is at its very best served warm, fresh from the oven. Pair it with a cup of Greek coffee or espresso, and you'll bring a little taste of the Mediterranean to your own kitchen.

WHAT YOU LEARNED

- Working confidently with filo pastry
- Making a smooth semolina custard
- Layering pastry correctly
- Creating crisp, flaky textures
- Finishing with a classic Greek presentation

KITCHEN CHALLENGE

[ ] Now that you've mastered traditional bougatsa, why not experiment with different fillings?
[ ] Apple and cinnamon
[ ] Orange custard
[ ] Dark chocolate
[ ] Ricotta and honey
[ ] Spinach and feta (savoury version)

CHAPTER 7

Troubleshooting Common Baking Problems

Understand the result, identify the likely cause and make one useful adjustment next time.

Baking problems are evidence, not failure. Use the appearance, texture and timing of a bake to identify what changed. Work through one adjustment at a time so the next result teaches you something clear.

1

My cake did not rise

Likely causes: The oven was not fully preheated, the raising agent was old, the tin was too large, or the batter waited too long before baking.

Try this next time: Check the expiry date on baking powder, preheat fully, use the specified tin and bake the batter promptly.

2

My cake sank in the centre

Likely causes: The oven door opened too early, the centre was underbaked, too much raising agent was used, or the batter was overmixed.

Try this next time: Keep the door closed until the final stage, measure carefully and test the centre before removing the cake.

3

My cake is dry

Likely causes: It baked too long, the oven ran hot, too much flour was measured, or the tin was wider than specified.

Try this next time: Weigh flour, check the oven with a thermometer and begin testing a few minutes before the stated time.

4

My cake or muffins are dense

Likely causes: The batter was overmixed, butter and sugar were not creamed enough, or cold ingredients prevented a smooth mixture.

Try this next time: Use room-temperature ingredients and stop mixing as soon as the flour disappears.

5

My bread is heavy or dense

Likely causes: The yeast was inactive, the dough did not rise long enough, too much flour was added, or the dough needed more development.

Try this next time: Use fresh yeast, keep the dough comfortably warm, judge the rise by volume rather than the clock and avoid adding unnecessary flour.

6

My pastry shrank

Likely causes: The dough was stretched into the tin, it was not rested, or the pastry became warm before baking.

Try this next time: Lower the pastry gently into the tin, chill it before baking and trim only after it has relaxed.

7

My pastry has a soggy base

Likely causes: The filling was too wet or warm, the pastry was underbaked, or the base needed blind baking.

Try this next time: Cool and drain fillings, preheat the oven well and blind bake when the recipe requires it.

8

My cookies spread too much

Likely causes: The butter was too warm, the tray was hot, too little flour was used, or the dough needed chilling.

Try this next time: Weigh the flour, cool the tray between batches and chill soft dough before baking.

9

My cookies are hard

Likely causes: They baked too long, too much flour was added, or the dough was overmixed.

Try this next time: Remove cookies when the edges are set but the centres still look slightly soft; they continue to firm as they cool.

10

My choux pastry collapsed

Likely causes: The pastry was underbaked, the oven door opened too soon, or steam could not escape after baking.

Try this next time: Bake until deeply golden and dry, keep the door closed, then pierce the shells briefly to release trapped steam.

CHAPTER 8

Chef Eliane's 20 Golden Baking Tips

Small habits that produce calmer preparation, cleaner technique and more reliable results.

Prepare with purpose

1

Read before you begin
Read the complete recipe once, then gather every ingredient and tool.

2

Weigh whenever possible
A digital scale gives repeatable results and prevents excess flour.

3

Prepare your mise en place
Measure ingredients, line tins and preheat the oven before mixing.

4

Respect ingredient temperature
Use room-temperature butter, eggs and dairy when the recipe asks for them.

5

Preheat fully
Give the oven enough time to reach a stable temperature before the bake goes in.

Build reliable technique

6

Know your oven
An inexpensive oven thermometer can reveal whether the displayed temperature is accurate.

7

Use the correct tin
Tin dimensions affect depth, baking time and the final texture.

8

Keep puff pastry cold
Cold butter layers create steam and the light, crisp lift that puff pastry needs.

9

Handle filo gently
Keep unused sheets covered with a barely damp towel so they remain flexible.

10

Cream with patience
Beat softened butter and sugar until noticeably paler and lighter.

Bake with attention

11

Do not overmix
After flour is added, mix only until no dry streaks remain unless instructed otherwise.

12

Fold with a light hand
Lift and turn the mixture to preserve the air already incorporated.

13

Give yeast time
Judge proofing by the dough's size and feel, not only by the clock.

14

Leave space on the tray
Airflow and room to spread help cookies and choux bake evenly.

15

Keep the door closed
Opening the oven too early can release the heat and steam needed for a proper rise.

Finish with care

16

Use visual signs
Colour, aroma, spring and a clean skewer are as important as the timer.

17

Cool on a rack
Air circulation prevents condensation and protects crisp bases.

18

Cool before glazing
Warm cakes melt icing and can turn a neat finish into a thin, uneven coating.

19

Change one thing at a time
When testing a variation, alter one ingredient or method so you can understand the result.

20

Keep a baking notebook
Record the tin, timing, oven setting and outcome so each bake teaches you something useful.

CHAPTER 9

Baking Conversions & Handy Reference

Use these practical charts as a quick companion when recipes, tins and oven settings differ.

Oven Temperature Conversions

Temperatures are practical equivalents. Ovens vary, so use colour, texture and an oven thermometer alongside the chart.

Conventional °C	Fan °C	°F	Gas Mark
110	90	225	¼
120	100	250	½
140	120	275	1
150	130	300	2
160	140	325	3
180	160	350	4
190	170	375	5
200	180	400	6
220	200	425	7
230	210	450	8
240	220	475	9

Cups, Grams and Millilitres

Cup-to-weight conversions are approximate because ingredients differ in density and measuring technique. Weigh ingredients whenever accuracy matters.

Volume

US volume	Metric volume
1 cup	240 ml
¾ cup	180 ml
⅔ cup	160 ml
½ cup	120 ml
⅓ cup	80 ml
¼ cup	60 ml
1 tablespoon	15 ml
1 teaspoon	5 ml

Common ingredient weights

Ingredient	1 cup, approximately
All-purpose flour	120 g
Granulated sugar	200 g
Packed brown sugar	220 g
Butter	227 g
Whole milk	240 ml
Vegetable oil	224 g
Honey or syrup	340 g
Cocoa powder	90 g
Rolled oats	90 g

Ingredient Substitutions

Substitutions can change flavour, structure and baking time. Use them for the situations noted, and avoid treating baking powder and baking soda as interchangeable.

When the recipe calls for	Practical substitute	Important note
240 ml buttermilk	240 ml milk mixed with 1 tbsp lemon juice or white vinegar; rest 5-10 minutes	Suitable for cakes, muffins and quick breads
1 cup cake flour	1 cup all-purpose flour minus 2 tbsp, plus 2 tbsp cornflour; sift well	Best for tender cakes
1 cup self-raising flour	1 cup all-purpose flour plus 1½ tsp baking powder and ¼ tsp fine salt	Do not add the recipe's raising agent twice
Greek yoghurt	Plain natural yoghurt or sour cream in the same quantity	Texture and acidity may vary slightly
1 egg for binding	1 tbsp ground flaxseed mixed with 3 tbsp water; rest until gelled	Works in many simple bakes, but not custards, choux or recipes where eggs provide most of the lift
Unsalted butter	A firm plant-based baking block in the same quantity	Flavour and water content differ; avoid soft spreadable tubs for pastry
Brown sugar	White sugar in the same quantity	The bake will be lighter in colour and less caramel-like

Pan Size Guide

These are close capacity matches, not exact replacements. A deeper batter usually needs more time; a shallower batter usually needs less. Fill tins only as directed by the recipe.

Pan / Size	Approximate Capacity / Equivalent	Typical Use
20 cm / 8 inch	18 cm / 7 inch	Small layer cake
23 cm / 9 inch	20 cm / 8 inch	Standard cake or brownie
25 cm / 10 inch	23 cm / 9 inch	Large cake
23 × 13 cm / 9 × 5 inch loaf	About 1.9 L capacity	Loaf cakes and quick breads
33 × 23 cm / 13 × 9 inch	About 3.8 L capacity	Tray bakes and large bakes
12-hole muffin tin	80-120 ml per cup	Cupcakes and muffins

Baking Terms Explained

Term	Meaning
Blind bake	Bake a pastry case before adding its filling, usually with baking paper and weights.
Bloom	Activate an ingredient, often yeast in liquid or gelatine in cold water, before using it.
Cream	Beat softened fat and sugar until pale and aerated.
Crumb	The internal texture and pattern of holes in bread, cake or pastry.
Dock	Prick pastry with a fork so trapped steam can escape.
Egg wash	Beaten egg, sometimes mixed with water or milk, brushed on pastry for colour and shine.
Fold	Combine a light mixture with a heavier one using gentle lifting and turning movements.
Knead	Work dough to develop gluten and create strength and elasticity.
Line	Cover a tin or tray with baking paper to reduce sticking and simplify removal.
Mise en place	Prepare and arrange all ingredients and equipment before beginning.
Proof	Allow yeast dough to rise before baking.
Ribbon stage	The point when beaten eggs and sugar fall from the whisk in a thick ribbon that briefly holds its shape.
Score	Make shallow cuts in dough or pastry to guide expansion or mark portions.
Soft peaks	Whipped cream or egg whites form a peak that bends over when the whisk is lifted.
Stiff peaks	Whipped cream or egg whites form a peak that stands upright when the whisk is lifted.
Temper	Gradually combine ingredients at different temperatures to prevent curdling or seizing.
Zest	The coloured outer layer of citrus peel, removed without the bitter white pith.

BONUS

Baking Pantry Essentials

A printable checklist for the ingredients that make spontaneous baking possible.

Baking Pantry Essentials Checklist

Always be ready to bake with this practical pantry checklist. Print this page and keep it in your kitchen so you can see what needs replenishing at a glance.

DRY INGREDIENTS

[ ] All-purpose flour (unbleached)
[ ] Baking powder (fresh)
[ ] Baking soda
[ ] Granulated white sugar
[ ] Light brown sugar
[ ] Sea salt or kosher salt

FLAVOR ENHANCERS

[ ] Pure vanilla extract
[ ] Ground cinnamon
[ ] Ground nutmeg
[ ] Ground ginger
[ ] Ground cardamom

FATS & MOISTURE

[ ] Unsalted butter (or plant-based alternative)
[ ] Neutral oil (like sunflower or grapeseed oil)
[ ] Nut butters (peanut, almond, etc.)

PROTEINS & BINDERS

[ ] Fresh eggs
[ ] Flaxseeds or chia seeds (for vegan baking)

SWEET ADDITIONS

[ ] Dark chocolate chips or chunks
[ ] Cocoa powder (Dutch-processed if possible)
[ ] Shredded coconut
[ ] Dried fruits (cranberries, apricots, raisins)
[ ] Maple syrup or honey
[ ] Sprinkles or edible decorations

GRAINS & EXTRAS

[ ] Rolled oats
[ ] Chopped nuts (walnuts, pecans, almonds)
[ ] Cornstarch (optional, for chewy cookie texture)

FINAL WORDS

A Note from Chef Eliane

Every bake adds skill, instinct and confidence to your kitchen.

Congratulations!

By reaching the end of this course, you've done much more than bake a few recipes. You've taken your first steps towards becoming a confident home baker.

I hope you've discovered that baking doesn't have to be complicated or intimidating. With a little patience, the right techniques and a willingness to learn, anyone can create delicious bakes to share with family and friends.

Remember, every experienced baker started exactly where you are today. There will be recipes that turn out perfectly and others that teach you valuable lessons. Both are part of the journey, and every time you step into the kitchen, you'll become a little more confident.

My greatest wish is that this course inspires you to keep experimenting, trying new flavours and enjoying the simple pleasure of baking something with your own hands.

Thank you for inviting me into your kitchen. It has been a pleasure baking alongside you, and I hope this is just the beginning of many wonderful baking adventures.

Until next time...

Happy Baking!

Chef Eliane

Epicurean Flow

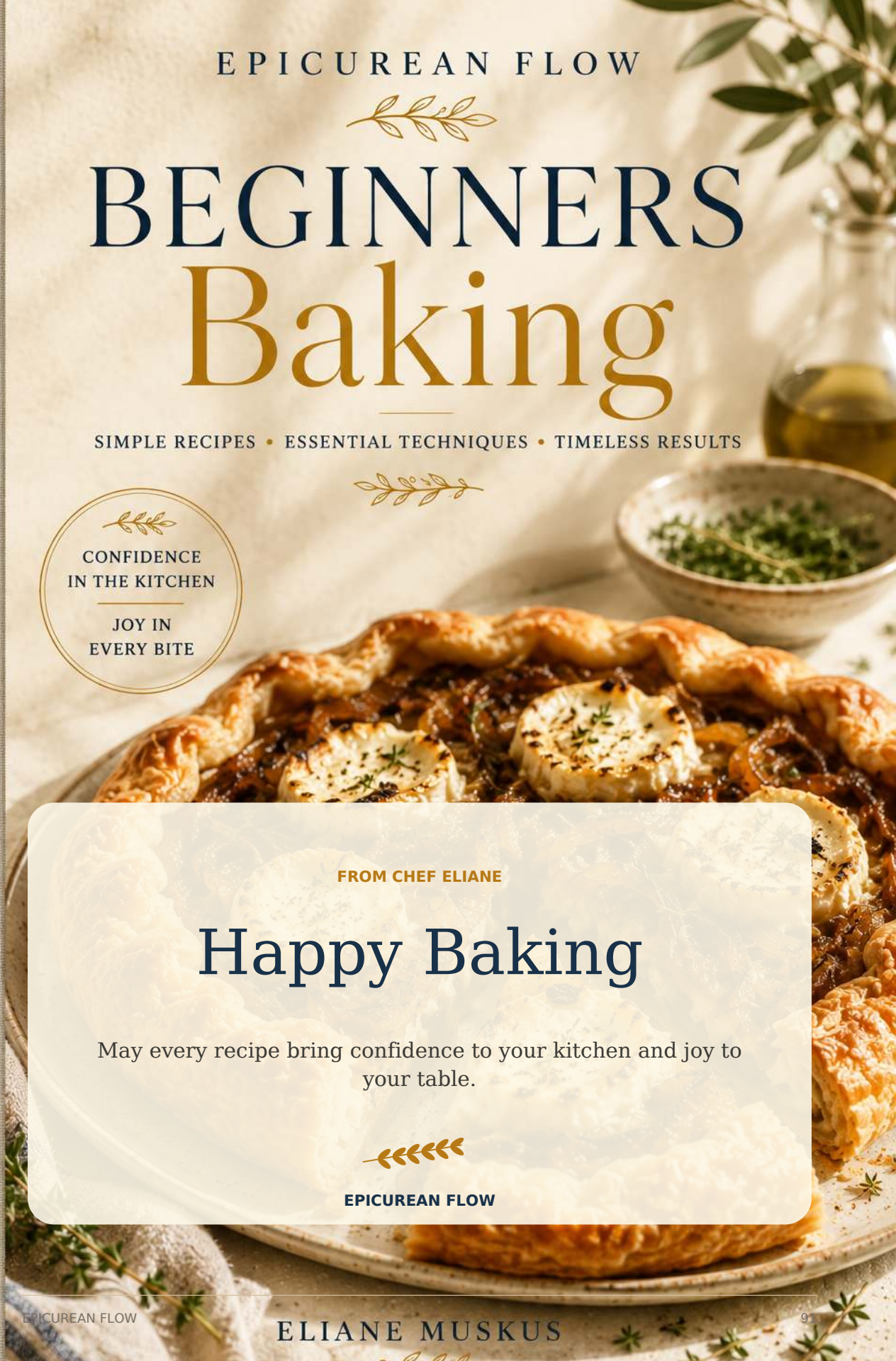
EPICUREAN FLOW

BEGINNERS Baking

SIMPLE RECIPES • ESSENTIAL TECHNIQUES • TIMELESS RESULTS

CONFIDENCE IN THE KITCHEN

JOY IN EVERY BITE



FROM CHEF ELIANE

Happy Baking

May every recipe bring confidence to your kitchen and joy to your table.

EPICUREAN FLOW